

DIVISION OF HOTELS & RESTAURANTS

THAWING VACUUM PACKED FISH

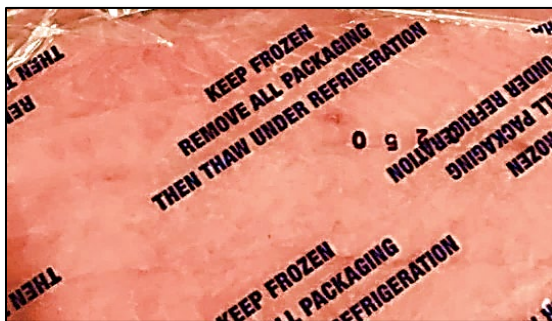
The Food Code requires that commercially vacuum packaged fish labeled with instructions to keep frozen must be removed from the reduced oxygen environment:

- Prior to thawing in a refrigerator; or
- Prior to or immediately upon completion of thawing under cold running water

FDA guidance has clarified that vacuum packaged fish must be entirely removed from the Reduced Oxygen Packaging (ROP) rather than partially cutting or piercing the package.

Effective January 1, 2026

The Division will start enforcing that commercially processed ROP fish with manufacturer's instructions to keep frozen until use to be completely removed from the package before thawing.



CAUTION: Fish has a higher risk of the bacteria *Clostridium botulinum* that can grow without oxygen at refrigerated temperatures in a vacuum package

If fish is vacuum packaged on-site, an approved HACCP plan is required. The ROP fish will need to be frozen before, during, and after packaging with labeling instructions to remove from packaging before thawing.

For more information, visit our website at:

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